



Alberto Moravia, Ennio Flaiano, Elsa Morante, Biccardo Bacchelli, Elio Vittorini, Giuseppe Berto—"literature as an art in Italy may be threatened by hand-to-mouth necessities."

again taking the case of Moravia, we may compare his two novelettes published in this country under the title "Two Adolescents" with a story he wrote around 1930 called "A Sick Boy's Winter" ("Inverno di malato"). We cannot fail to realize that the quality and also to a certain extent the themes are similar, and that the older work remains one of Moravia's best. If it had been published in this country at the time it was written it would have passed unnoticed as did two novels by the same author published in an American translation in the Thirties. To give another example, Elio Vittorini's "In Sicily," which was quite widely acclaimed in England and was accompanied in this country by Ernest Hemingway's presentation, was reviewed on the front page of at least one major weekly book review; it had been written and published in Italy before the war. It is a safe bet that if it had been suggested to an American publisher at that time it would not have seemed an interesting investment.

The mechanism of literary success is difficult enough to analyze within one country; it is even more so on the international level. Italian literature has not been prominent on that level for decades, in fact perhaps for centuries; so that the present focusing of attention takes in even work of the past, with the appearance of a popular new version of the "Inferno" by Dorothy Sayers and with serious recognition being given to Alessandro Manzoni's nineteenth-century novel "The Betrothed" in the new Colquhoun

version. Italian writers of a European caliber, such as Leopardi in the early nineteenth century, never received the success which they certainly deserved; the few serious students of Italian at American universities usually discover them with amazement.

HISTORICALLY the neglect of Italian literature was also due in part to the discouraging provincialism of the writers' atmosphere. In our own century, the last Italian to achieve any recognition before the present revival was Luigi Pirandello—though not for his very valuable, however "provincial," fiction, but for his drama. There is such a thing as a social history of literature, the kind of history that is made in "influential circles," salons, cafés, groups, editorial offices. A young writer finding one of these at his disposal from the start in his own country has, like a boy born into a wealthy family, a considerable advantage; he is recognizable, placeable. Otherwise he has to advance alone, as far as international recognition goes, without support from his native background, eventually perhaps grafting himself onto an already existing cosmopolitan tradition and its facilities. Pirandello's drama availed itself of channels of international success which were, roughly speaking, those that had been opened a few decades earlier by Ibsen. Pirandello, like Ibsen, became very popular in Germany, where the metaphysics of his plays had great appeal; and in Paris, where advanced literary figures still usually received their world baptism. World

recognition came to him with the Nobel Prize and with a Hollywood version of one of his plays as a vehicle for Greta Garbo.

Before winning such solemn and safely commercial accolades, Pirandello had been *avant garde*. For instance, his famous play "Six Characters in Search of an Author" had caused violent indignation and controversy, even fist fights; the bourgeoisie of Europe at first had granted him something of a *succès de scandale*. It is important to recall this because such a form of success seems useful, in fact almost necessary at times. In other words, it seems that there must always be spurious elements in the workings of literary fame; the semblance of outrageous novelty, a "scandal" of some sort, or even a successful though perhaps irrelevant slogan or tag applied to a group. Slogans and tags may be vaguely explained to, and even more vaguely understood by, the public, but they help give the idea that a literary event is taking place. They give audiences a point on which to focus their attention, whether it be an attention born of admiration, outrage, or of some sort of magnified gossip. Many people who buy and read the recent French writers would be at a loss to give a workable definition of existentialism, yet it is partly through that inexplicable name that they have been drawn to the writers; it is also typical that some of the writers themselves refuse connection with the movement they are supposed to belong to, or fail to recognize such a movement at all.

Thus the recent "emergence of a new group" of Italian writers and film-makers vaguely tagged as "neo-realistic" is quite illusory since those writers and film makers are neither necessarily new nor a group, nor are they in any specialized way "realists"; yet the existence of some tag, however imprecise, helped them to be recognized, to become visible on the international literary scene, whether they were conscious of what was happening to them or not.

On the whole, they were not conscious of it. Italian writers were no longer used, as we have said, to any sort of world success *en masse*. In the early part of the century the only other Italian writer known internationally besides Pirandello had been Gabriele d'Annunzio, the nature of whose fame had extra-literary connotations, and whose literary example the new Italian writers abhorred. In an important sense, Italian literature, and especially poetry, had been characterized after D'Annunzio by a re-

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